

SINGH IS NOW ONLINE KING

Computer and online games are acquiring Bollywood and contemporary Indian themes to cater to the Indian market

■ By Swagata Sen

Even a month before the Aamir Khan-starring film, *Ghajini*, hits the theatres, a group of geeks would know exactly how to out-Aamir Aamir, and not just in terms of a haircut. By October, the *Ghajini* PC game would be on the market, and gamers around the world would have relived *Ghajini* a number of times. Similarly, biker-types, who have been waiting for the third installment after *Dhoom 2*, can take heart in something in between—*Dhoom 2.5*. The game has all the thrills and vrooming that the film version has, complete with Bollywoodian song and dance, and what's more, you can play

your own role in the game.

This is the golden era of Indian gaming. An industry that would, sitting in India, create games for overseas clients with mostly American characters is now giving way to Indian-themed PC or Internet games. "We are focusing on games that are local and relevant in story content and game flavour made with Indian players in mind," says Sashi Reddi, Hyderabad-based chairman of FX Labs Studio that has chosen Hindi film-based games as its new mantra.

One of the biggest success stories is that of games2win.com, a website that primarily has Indian Flash games, and where anything in news in India immediately has them making a game out of

it. On August 15, it launched the Singh is King game, which has Prime Minister Manmohan Singh trying to save himself from losing his MPs, and is set in Delhi. Bollywood Buckwuss has a Salman Khan-lookalike trying to avoid shooting a black buck in a jungle, while The Great Indian Arranged Marriage has prospective brides and grooms going through seven stages. Alok Kejriwal, the co-founder and CEO of games2win, says he started his gaming company as an offshoot of his 10-year-old branding company, contests2win, in March 2007. Little did he know that Bombay



The Singh is King game (top) and programmers at a gaming website making games out of news



PHILIP K. PAUL